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April 7, 2026

ENGROSSED HOUSE
BILL NO. 3499

By: Duel of the House

and

Howard of the Senate

An Act relating to courts; amending 20 O.S. 2021, Section 123, which relates to the jurisdiction of special judges; authorizing special judges to hear and decide applications for court orders to issue titles; and providing an effective date.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

SECTION 1. AMENDATORY 20 O.S. 2021, Section 123, is amended to read as follows:

Section 123. A. Special judges may hear and decide the following:

1. Actions for the recovery of money where the amount claimed does not exceed Ten Thousand Dollars (\$10,000.00) and counterclaim or setoff does not exceed Ten Thousand Dollars (\$10,000.00);

2. All uncontested matters, whether by default, agreement, or otherwise, except that a nonlawyer special judge may not hear any uncontested matters, whether by default, agreement, or otherwise, in actions for the recovery of money where judgment is sought for a greater sum than One Thousand Dollars (\$1,000.00);

1 3. Actions for forcible entry and detainer except a nonlawyer
2 special judge may not hear such actions if title to land or a
3 boundary dispute is involved;

4 4. Actions for replevin where the amount in controversy does
5 not exceed Ten Thousand Dollars (\$10,000.00), except that nonlawyer
6 special judges may not hear such actions where the amount in
7 controversy exceeds One Thousand Dollars (\$1,000.00);

8 5. Misdemeanors, except that special judges who are not lawyers
9 may not hear criminal actions where the punishment prescribed by law
10 exceeds a fine of Two Hundred Dollars (\$200.00), or imprisonment in
11 a county jail for thirty (30) days, or both such fine and
12 imprisonment except by written consent of all parties;

13 6. Felonies involving a second and subsequent offense of
14 driving, operating, or being in actual physical control of a motor
15 vehicle while under the influence of alcohol or any other
16 intoxicating substance, including any controlled dangerous substance
17 as defined in the Uniform Controlled Dangerous Substances Act, to a
18 degree that renders the defendant incapable of safely driving or
19 operating a motor vehicle, except that nonlawyer special judges may
20 not hear such matters;

21 7. When there is no district or associate district judge
22 present in the county or when they are disqualified, the issuance of
23 a temporary injunction or restraining order, but this paragraph
24 shall not embrace nonlawyer special judges;

1 8. Issuance of writs of habeas corpus, but this paragraph shall
2 not embrace nonlawyer special judges;

3 9. Any matter, regardless of value, at any stage, whether
4 intermediate or final, and whether or not title to property, real,
5 personal, tangible, intangible, or any combination thereof, is to be
6 determined, in a probate, divorce, domestic relations, custody,
7 support, guardianship, conservatorship, mental health, juvenile,
8 adoption, or determination of death proceeding, except that
9 nonlawyer special judges may not hear such matters;

10 10. An appeal from an order of the Department of Public Safety
11 revoking a person's license to drive, except that nonlawyer special
12 judges may not hear such matters;

13 11. Other actions and proceedings, regardless of court rules,
14 where the parties agree in writing, at any time before trial, to the
15 action being heard by a special judge;

16 12. Any postjudgment collection matter regardless of the amount
17 of the judgment; ~~and~~

18 13. Youthful offender cases pursuant to the Youthful Offender
19 Act; and

20 14. Applications for court orders to issue titles including,
21 but not limited to, applications seeking an order directing the
22 issuance, reissuance, correction, or replacement of certificates of
23 title for motor vehicles, manufactured homes, vessels, or other
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1 titled property, and to enter such orders as may be necessary and
2 proper to effectuate the issuance of title.

3 B. Special judges shall be authorized to serve as referee in
4 any matter before the district court.

5 C. A special judge may perform the duties of a magistrate in
6 criminal cases.

7 SECTION 2. This act shall become effective November 1, 2026.

8 COMMITTEE REPORT BY: COMMITTEE ON JUDICIARY
9 April 7, 2026 - DO PASS
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